

Narrative Essay Writing: Structure and Introductory Paragraph Expository Writing – Week 7

- **A Narrative is a STORY.**

- **Purpose:**

- A narrative text tells a story. Provide details in the sequence in which the events occur.
- There has to be a complication to increase the interest of the reader
- The story must have a definite ending.

Personal Narrative

- A story about a **moment** in your own life.
- A personal narrative focuses on a single event or moment in your life.
- Personal narratives tend to depict change. Maybe your skill level changes, your beliefs change, the way you understand the world changes, your mood or habits change...etc. Often, characters learn something from the change.

I still remember the day I walked into my first class as a teacher. My hands were trembling, and I kept wondering if I was truly ready for this responsibility. As I stood in front of the students, my voice felt unsteady, and for a moment, I doubted myself.

But as I began to speak, something shifted. The students listened attentively, some nodding, others taking notes. Their engagement gave me confidence, and I slowly found my rhythm. By the end of the class, I was no longer afraid; I was excited. That day taught me an important lesson: confidence does not come before the experience; it grows within it. Stepping into that classroom changed not only how I saw teaching, but also how I saw myself.

Fictional Narrative

- A story about a **moment** in a made-up character's life.
- You create the characters, setting, and conflict, but it should still focus on a single event or moment (because this is a SHORT story!)
- I will tell the story of the moment when my character got lost in the woods.

The night the clock stopped ticking, Ayaan knew something was wrong. The streets outside his window were frozen, cars paused mid-motion, birds suspended in the sky. Heart racing, he stepped outside and realized he was the only one still moving.

As he wandered through the silent city, he discovered a glowing pocket watch lying on the ground. The moment he picked it up, the world flickered. A whisper echoed, "You control the time now." With every turn of the watch, people moved again, but only as he allowed them to. Ayaan soon understood that this strange power was not a gift, but a responsibility. And as the city waited in silence, he had to decide: should time return to normal, or should he reshape the world forever?

Point of View

1st Person:

“I never thought that owning a dog would be so challenging.

When I brought Fluffy home for the first time, she destroyed my favorite pair of shoes within five minutes. After I found the damage, I locked Fluffy in her crate.”

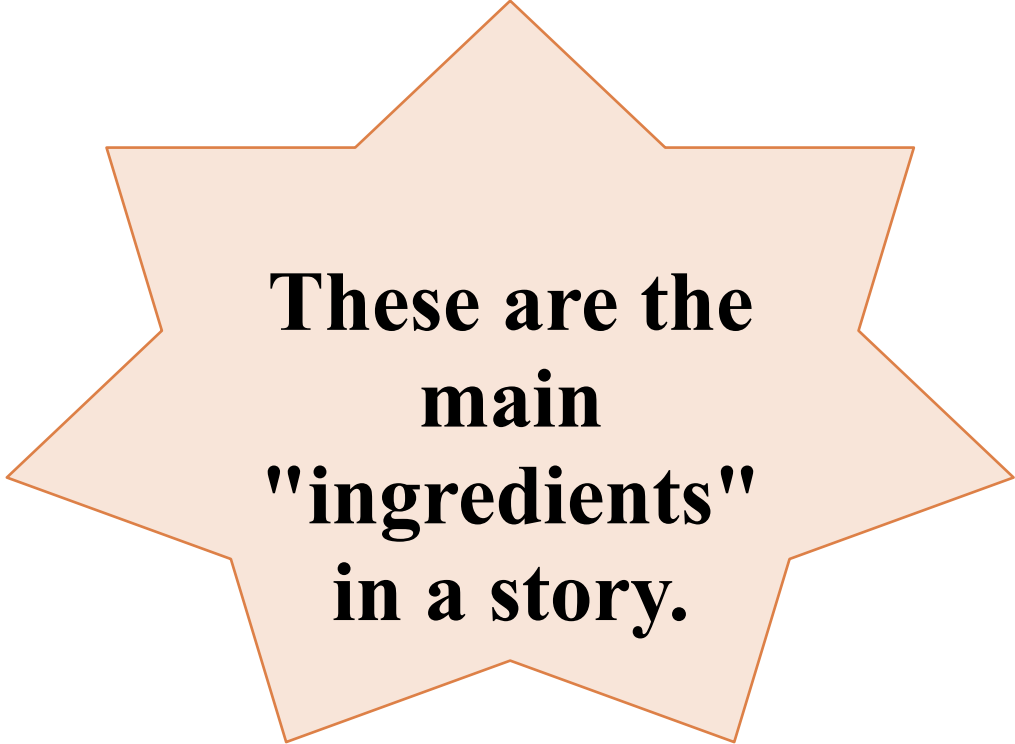
3rd Person:

“Amber used to think that owning a dog would be easy, but when she brought Fluffy home for the first time, she discovered she was wrong. Fluffy had destroyed her favourite pair of shoes. When Amber saw them, she locked Fluffy in her crate.”

Narrative Elements

The main elements that apply to narratives are:

1. Character
2. Setting
3. Conflict
4. Plot
5. Theme



**These are the
main
"ingredients"
in a story.**

1. Character

- The main people (or other living things) that are involved in your story.
- Describe your characters are through their behaviours.

2. Setting

- Where do different scenes in your story take place?



3. Conflict

Man vs. Man



Man vs. Society



Man vs. Technology



Types of Conflict

Man vs. Nature



Man vs. Self



Man vs. Supernatural



INTERNAL VS EXTERNAL

- **Internal conflicts** are often the most compelling, as they offer insight into a character's motivations and inner turmoil.
- **External conflicts** usually involve a character battling against a force outside of them, such as another person or nature itself.

7 TYPES

Internal Conflicts

- Man vs Self
- Man vs Destiny

External Conflicts

- Man vs Society
- Man vs Nature
- Man vs Technology
- Man vs Man
- Man vs Supernatural

Elements of a Plot

Climax

the peak of action and conflict



Conflict

a struggle between opposing forces that drives the action of the story



Rising Action

the portion of the story where the conflict increases

Falling Action

the portion of the story where the conflict decreases



Exposition

the introduction of the characters and the basic situation



Resolution

the outcome of the conflict



5. Theme

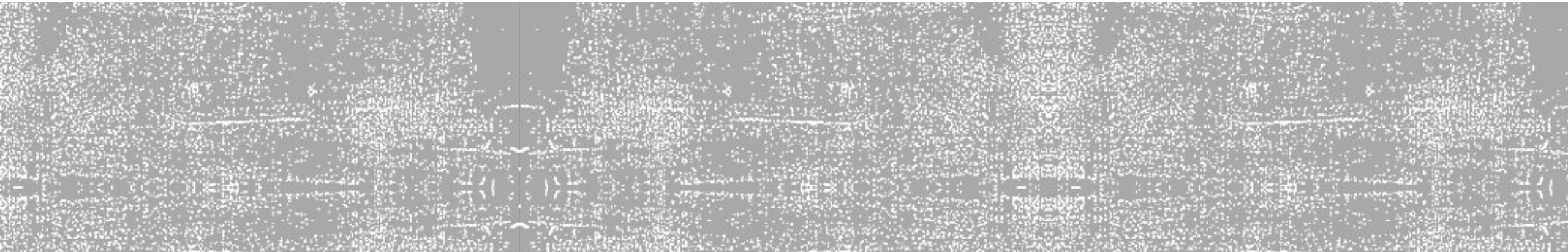
What does the story seek to tell us about life or human nature? What's the message of the story?

- Write a story that means something more to readers than the surface-level enjoyment of events in the plot.
- Don't make your theme/message obvious or repetitive.





In-Class Activity



A man stands under a tree. He is pacing up and down nervously. He glances at his watch every few seconds. There are only 9 seconds left for the bomb to tick. Nervously, he tries to defuse the bomb by cutting the wire and then ‘kaboomb’. He wakes up with a jolt and is relieved that it was all a dream.

- Student one: asks the question, “And then what?”
- Student two: answers by describing what happens next.
- Student three: “And then what?”
- repeat until you have worked through the

Problem: This is the beginning of the story where the main characters, setting, and the central conflict (problem) are introduced.

rising action: A series of events that build tension and develop the conflict. The protagonist faces challenges that escalate the stakes.

Climax: The turning point of the story, usually the most intense or dramatic moment. The protagonist makes a crucial decision or faces their biggest challenge.

falling action: The events that follow the climax and lead to a resolution. Conflicts start to resolve, and loose ends begin to tie up.

and resolution: The conclusion of the story where conflicts are fully resolved, and the story comes to an end.





5-PARAGRAPH STRUCTURE

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- **Introduction**
 1. Write a hook(rhetorical question, interesting fact, anecdote) that helps your reader relate to the senses you're tapping into.
 2. Provide some general background/setting/ introduce characters
 3. Form a three-point thesis statement that makes a claim
 4. Transitional hook
- **Paragraph 2: Rising Action** – Develops a problem or conflict leading up to the climax and provides supporting details
- **Paragraph 3: Climax** – Clearly develops the turning point of the story where the problem or conflict reaches its peak and provides supporting details
- **Paragraph 4: Falling Action** – Clearly develops the events after the climax or turning point that lead to the resolution and provides supporting details
- **Conclusion: Resolution** – Clearly reveals the solution to the problem. Rephrasing thesis. Provides a concluding remark/statement



Introductory Paragraph

1. Write a hook(rhetorical question, anecdote) that helps your reader relate to the senses you're tapping into.
2. Provide some general background/setting/ introduce characters
3. Form a three-point thesis statement that makes a claim
4. Transitional hook

1. Reader's Hook

Begin with action or dialogue (an anecdote):

1. *I crouched in starting position; hands poised on the track and back coiled like a spring. "On your mark! Get set!" The starting gun boomed. I launched myself forward, trying to spring ahead of the pack.*
2. *The wind swirled around me, and the world went black...*
3. *"Surprise!" They cried, leaping out from behind the door...*
4. *It's a strange and scary sensation to suddenly forget your own name...*
5. *I have always hated chocolate, so I was more surprised than anybody to find myself standing outside of the quaint chocolate shop on the outskirts of town...*
6. *Bright morning sunlight was shining through my bedroom window when I woke. I lay there lazily for a few minutes, then jumped out of bed...*
7. *It was supposed to be a fun hike through the woods, but nobody could have imagined what it would become...*



OR

A Rhetorical Question:

- *Why does trouble always follow me around? Do I have a "kick me" sign on my back or something?*
- Have you ever had a feeling that something wasn't right? That's how I felt the day...
- **Choose ONE topic and write 2 different hooks (one of each type):**
 - A day I will never forget
 - A moment of fear
 - My first big achievement



2. Lead in- Provide some general background/setting/ introduce characters

2. Describe the setting, characters, and background information

- *I sat cradled in three branches at the top of an old oak behind my house. I could see over the rooftop, could see for miles. Overhead, planes lined up in the sky, heading toward O'Hare Airport to land one by one.*
- *Taha my little brother, is in the first grade. He's fearless. One day, he wore a cape to school. I told him everyone would laugh at him. The next day, five other boys came wearing capes.*
- **Or have the main character introduce himself or herself.**
- *I'm Talia. I just turned 13, and I'm here to tell you a secret.*



Develop a
lead-in for
the topic
in the
previous
slide



3. Thesis Statement

- **A three-point thesis statement for a narrative essay should:**
- **Make a clear claim** about the story's purpose or theme.
- **Outline three key points** that support the claim.
- **Guide the reader on what to expect** in the essay.



Steps to Create a Three-Point Thesis Statement

- **Step 1:** Identify the Main Theme or Lesson (Topic). What is the main message of your story?
- **Step 2:** What did you learn or experience that changed you? (claim/stance)
- **Step 3:** Select three moments, events, or reflections that support your theme. (rising action, climax, falling action)
- **Step 4:** Write Your Thesis Statement: Structure: Lesson+Main claim + 3 Supporting points (Rising action +Climax +Falling Action)
- **Example:**
 - “Overcoming fear helped me become more confident by teaching me to take risks, embrace failure, and trust my abilities.”
 - “Moving to a new country changed my life by exposing me to new cultures, teaching me resilience, and helping me form meaningful friendships.”
- **Develop thesis statements on the following topics:**
 - A day I will never forget
 - A moment of fear
 - My first big achievement



Essay Type	Thesis Structure	Supporting Aspects	Example Thesis
Expository Essay	Topic + Main Idea/Claim + Supporting Points	Point 1: First explanation or reason Point 2: Second explanation or reason Point 3: Third explanation or reason	Online education benefits students by improving flexibility, reducing costs, and expanding access to learning.
Descriptive Essay	Topic + Claim / Expression + Supporting Descriptions	Physical Description: Sensory details about appearance (sight, smell, sound, texture). Contextual Description: Background, setting, or environment surrounding the subject. Emotional Description: Feelings, memories, or personal reactions associated with the subject.	My grandmother’s kitchen is a place of warmth and nostalgia, filled with the aroma of freshly baked bread, the soft glow of antique lamps, and memories of summers spent baking cookies together.
Narrative Essay	Lesson + Story Experience + Supporting Plot Events	Rising Action: Events that develop the conflict or problem and build tension in the story. Climax: The most intense moment when the main conflict reaches its peak. Falling Action / Resolution: Events after the climax that show how the problem is resolved and what the narrator learns.	Getting lost during my first solo journey taught me the importance of patience and independence as I wandered searching for directions, confronted panic, and gained confidence to trust my own decisions.

Introductory Paragraph – Personal Narrative

Anecdote

Lead-in

Thesis

Transitional
hook with 2
forward points

The moment my name was announced, my hands turned cold and my heart began to race uncontrollably. I remember standing backstage on the day of my first public presentation, the bright lights ahead and the low murmur of the audience filling the room. As someone who had always avoided speaking in front of others, I felt completely unprepared for what lay ahead. Facing my fear of public speaking helped me grow as a person by teaching me to manage anxiety, build confidence, and express myself clearly. As I walked onto the stage, my overwhelming anxiety and fear of failure began to shape the challenges I had to confront.



Introductory Paragraph – Fictional Narrative

Anecdote

Lead-in

Thesis

Transitional
hook with 2
forward points

It started with a strange silence, the kind that felt heavier than noise itself. One cold evening, as shadows stretched across empty streets, a young boy noticed that everything, cars, people, even the wind, had frozen in place. Confused and frightened, Armaan realised he was completely alone in a motionless world. Being trapped in a frozen world forced Arman to change by making him confront isolation, exploring his curiosity, and taking responsibility for his newfound power. As Arman stepped into the silent streets, his growing sense of seclusion and curiosity pushed him to uncover the mystery around him.



Introduction		10
Reader's hook (Anecdote, rhetorical question) is engaging and relevant	2	
Setting the scene/Background: Provides the information the reader will need to understand the story: setting, characters, background	1	
Three-Point Thesis Statement : offers a moral or lesson learned along with three points in parallel (rising action, climax, falling action)	5	
Transitional Hook: Hints upon the problem/conflict or rising action	1	
Mechanics: spelling, punctuation, Verb tenses correct Subject/verb agreement Contractions and idioms used when appropriate	1	



Write Introductory Paragraph

Write an introductory paragraph on one of the topics below:

- One Memory That Survived Everything
- The Day My Senses Vanished
- Behind the Perfect Hidden Illusion
- My Secret Rules for Survival
- A Family Full of Hidden Secrets

